

Recognizing and Responding to Heart Attack and Stroke Warning Signs — Free Preview

FRONT MATTER

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Accessibility: Plain-language explanation, defined vocabulary, and alt-text for visuals where applicable.

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CHAPTER 1

Recognizing and Responding to Heart Attack and Stroke Warning Signs

Emergency readiness skill: Identify warning signs, call for help quickly, and support the person safely while waiting for emergency responders.

Educational Disclaimer

This lesson is for education only. It does not replace emergency medical care, professional first-aid/CPR training, or instructions from emergency services.

If you think someone may be having a heart attack or stroke, call 911 or your local emergency number immediately.

CHAPTER 2

Learning Goals

By the end of this lesson, you will be able to:

- Recognize common warning signs of a heart attack
- Recognize common warning signs of a stroke
- Use FAST and BE-FAST to remember stroke warning signs
- Take safe first steps while waiting for emergency help

Practice what to say when calling 911

Decide when to act instead of waiting

CHAPTER 3

Key Plain-Language Definitions

Heart attack: A medical emergency that happens when blood flow to part of the heart is blocked.

Stroke: A medical emergency that happens when blood flow to part of the brain is blocked or when bleeding occurs in the brain.

Last known well: The last time the person was known to be normal, without stroke symptoms.

Dispatcher: The emergency call-taker who answers 911 and gives instructions until help arrives.

CHAPTER 4

When in doubt, call 911.

If you suspect a heart attack or stroke:

Call 911 or your local emergency number immediately

Do not wait to see if symptoms go away

Do not drive the person to the hospital yourself unless emergency services tells you to

Follow dispatcher instructions

Fast action can save a life and reduce long-term damage.

A heart attack can be sudden and intense, but it can also start slowly with mild discomfort.

Symptoms may come and go. They may feel like pressure, pain, heaviness, burning, or tightness.

CHAPTER 5

Common Heart Attack Warning Signs

Call 911 if someone has any of the following, especially if symptoms are new, severe, unusual, or do not quickly improve:

Chest pain, pressure, squeezing, fullness, or discomfort

Pain or discomfort spreading to the:

Arm

Shoulder

Back

Neck

Jaw

Stomach

Shortness of breath

Cold sweat

Nausea or vomiting

Lightheadedness, dizziness, or fainting

Unusual tiredness or weakness, especially if sudden or unexplained

A sense that “something is very wrong”

CHAPTER 6

Important Note: Symptoms Can Look Different

Heart attack symptoms may not look the same for everyone.

Women, older adults, and people with diabetes may have less obvious symptoms, such as:

Shortness of breath

Nausea

Unusual fatigue

Back, neck, jaw, or stomach discomfort

Lightheadedness

Weakness without severe chest pain

Do not ignore mild or unusual symptoms if they could be heart-related.

CHAPTER 7

Heart Attack Response Steps

If you think someone may be having a heart attack:

1. Call 911 immediately.
2. Have the person sit or rest in a comfortable position.
3. Keep the person calm and still.
4. Loosen tight clothing, such as a tight collar, tie, belt, or waistband.
5. Do not give food or drink.
6. Do not give aspirin unless emergency dispatch or a medical professional recommends it, and only if the person is not allergic

and has no known reason they should avoid it.

7. Monitor breathing and responsiveness.

8. Be ready to start CPR or use an AED if the person becomes unresponsive and you are trained or instructed by the dispatcher.

9. Stay with the person until help arrives.

10. Follow dispatcher instructions.

CHAPTER 8

Quick Check 1: Could This Be a Heart Attack?

8.1 Scenario

Your uncle says he has heavy pressure in his chest. He is sweating, feels nauseated, and says the discomfort is spreading to his jaw.

What should you do first?

A. Offer him food and water

B. Wait 30 minutes to see if it improves

C. Call 911 or your local emergency number immediately

D. Drive him yourself without calling

8.2 Correct Answer

C. Call 911 or your local emergency number immediately.

Chest pressure, sweating, nausea, and pain spreading to the jaw are possible heart attack signs. Fast emergency care matters.

CHAPTER 9

Decision Prompt: Wait or Call?

For each situation, decide: Call 911 now or Wait and watch.

Situation	Best Response
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A person has chest pressure and shortness of breath.	Call 911 now
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A person has sudden jaw discomfort, nausea, and cold sweating.	Call 911 now
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A person says, “It’s probably nothing,” but they look pale, weak, and dizzy.	Call 911 now
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A person has mild chest discomfort after exercise that feels unusual and does not quickly improve.	Call 911 now
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9.1 QRU Safety Reminder

If symptoms could be a heart attack, do not wait for certainty. Emergency responders would rather be called early than too late.

CHAPTER 10

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